The Social Construction of Partisanship: Misperceptions About Party Composition and Partisan Identification

According to a leading account, people tend to think about political parties in terms of other, longer-standing groups (Berelson, Lazarsfeld and McPhee 1954; Green, Palmquist and Schickler 2002; Campbell et al. 1960; Converse 1964; Mason 2016). As a result, how people feel about parties' constituent groups is said to drive how they feel about the parties. In fact, Green, Palmquist and Schickler (2002, p. 8) contend that people identify with the party whose "assemblage of groups" best reflects their own group memberships. This may help explain one of the enduring mysteries in mass politics: entrenched partisanship coupled with political disinterest and widespread ignorance of the parties' policy positions.

For a psychological theory of such prominence, however, most of the supporting evidence is circumstantial—unchanging party affiliation in face of changing economic conditions or economically consequential policy shifts by parties (e.g., Achen and Bartels 2016; Gamm 1989; Green, Palmquist and Schickler 2002), coupled with group identity's ability to explain partisan affiliation after controlling for policy preferences (Dawson 1994). We still largely lack direct evidence for the claim that people's group identities, coupled with their beliefs about party composition, drive partisan identification.

Ahler and Sood (2015) make some headway in filling this empirical gap, finding that most people overestimate the share of partisans belonging to party-stereotypical groups. They also demonstrate that correcting people's misperceptions about the share of party-stereotypical groups in the opposing party reduces animus toward the opposing party. However, some fundamental questions remain. First, do these beliefs cause a person to identify with a party, as the group-based theory of partisanship suggests? And second, do people's own group identities moderate such a relationship? That is, do individuals identify with their party more because

they they think the groups they belong to are overrepresented in the party—or, conversely, less because they believe out-groups are overrepresented?

To shed light on these questions, we propose an information provision experiment with three conditions. In the `ask` condition, respondents will report beliefs about the share of three party-stereotypical in their in-party before responding to dependent variables pertaining to partisan identification. In the `tell` condition, respondents will once again report the share of the three groups in their party, but will receive correct answers before responding to the dependent variables. Finally, in the `control` condition, respondents will answer the dependent measures before responding to any of the party composition items.

Drawing on recent research on party stereotypes (Ahler and Sood 2015; Busby et al. 2016), we plan to ask Democrats (based on pre-survey partisan identification available in the panel file) their beliefs about the percentage of co-partisans who are non-white, atheist or agnostic, and "millennials" (between the ages of 18 and 34). And we plan to ask Republicans about their beliefs about the percentage of co-partisans who are wealthy (earning $250K or more), evangelical, and residing in rural areas. (SI 1 provides the exact question text.) For dependent measures, we plan to ask the standard branched partisanship question, and the entire expressive partisanship battery from Huddy, Mason and Aaroe 2015.[1]

Our hypotheses are drawn from the group-oriented approach to partisanship. According to Green, Palmquist and Schickler (2002), people identify with parties to the extent that they perceive one party as being composed of "people like them." As such, when respondents are exposed to information that their party is more "like them" (on average), they should identify

[1] Green, Palmquist and Schickler (2002, p. 37-38) analyze the relationship between the traditional 7-point measure and the expressive identification measures similar to those in Huddy, Mason and Aaroe (2015), and conclude that, "self-categorization and group identification are empirically quite similar phenomena." We rely on a composite measures because we expect the effect to be small, and to be able to observe small effects, we need to ensure that the measure is as reliable as possible. Note, however, that a 7-point measure was a reliable enough instrument for a recent survey experiment. Kuo, Malhotra and Mo (2014) prime Asian-American political interests and the parties' positions on various immigration issues and observe a significant 5% treatment effect on Asian-American respondents' partisan self-identification on a sample size similar to what we are requesting.

more strongly with the party. This is our hypothesized main effect.

There are three nuances. First, while the `ask` condition does not offer correct information, merely asking for numerical estimates likely affects people's beliefs (see, Ahler and Sood Forthcoming). Asking people to give numerical estimates of the share of the party stereotypical groups in the parties likely makes them confront the implausibly large numbers that stereotypes implicitly map to, and forces them to downwardly revise their beliefs. (Correspondingly, curtailing the time people have to report their beliefs somewhat increases reported shares of party-stereotypical groups (Ahler and Sood Forthcoming).) As such, the conventional group identity account would posit that these lower estimates of shares of party-stereotypical groups would increase identification with parties, on average, across all respondents.

Second, we hypothesize that the size of respondents' misperceptions will moderate the treatment effect. That is, people with the most stereotype-inflated beliefs about their party's composition will move the most after receiving the correct information, as the potential correction is the greatest for them.

Thirdly, the conventional group identity account predicts that treatment effects will vary by the degree to which people identify with party-stereotypical groups. For example, it predicts that a non-wealthy, non-evangelical, urban or suburban Republican will be more likely to identify with the GOP after receiving the "tell" treatment; the respondent would learn that the party "looks more like him" than he previously thought (Green, Palmquist and Schickler 2002). By contrast, the treatment should have a more tepid effect on an urban, Catholic, wealthy Republican. Assuming the respondent overestimates the percentage of Republicans who belong to all three groups, he would learn that his party is more like him than he thought in two ways, but also less like him in one way. And the group identity account predicts that a wealthy, rural, evangelical Republican would identify less strongly with the party upon learning he overestimated how common "his" groups are in the Republican coalition.

The conventional group identity account is but one possibility. A compelling alternative

exists. Many party-stereotypical groups comprise relatively small shares in "their" parties—e.g., the hyper-wealthy in the GOP and atheists/agnostics in the Democratic Party. Not only that, partisans overestimate the share of these stereotypical groups, which tend not to "look like them," in their in-parties (Ahler and Sood 2015). And yet, people appear to like their party a great deal (e.g., Iyengar, Sood and Lelkes 2012). This suggests that people may identify with parties based on *affect toward* party-stereotypical groups rather than *identification with*.

We present observational evidence from the 2015 IGS-California Poll (sampling by SSI) that shed some light on our hypotheses. We measured people's feeling towards the party-stereotypical groups and the parties, and their perceptions of the share of the stereotypical groups in the party. To analyze how people's feeling toward the party are shaped by the perceived share of the group in the party, and their feelings toward the group, we created a measure of group dislike X perceived group prevalence in the in-party by reverse coding feeling thermometers for all groups i and multiplying them by respondents' answers to Pr(i | in-party). As we show in SI 3, across multiple specifications, the more people see their party as being composed of party-stereotypical groups they dislike, the more socially distant they feel from the party they identify with. Our observational analysis cannot sort out the two alternative accounts we present above. Because Americans tend to hold biased beliefs about party composition (which our treatment challenges), and because partisans vary in the degree to which they belong to party-stereotypical groups, the experimental design presented here can provide more leverage.

We propose fielding a survey experiment among weak partisans and partisan leaners (respondents who put themselves on 2, 3, 5, or 6 on the a 7-point party identification scale in the panel file). We do so for three reasons. First, party identification is often called the "unmoved mover." Thus, we expect effects to be small and are concerned about adequate power to detect these small but theoretically meaningful changes. Second, strong partisans, who often have more policy-based reasons to identify with the party and are more likely to reason in a motivated manner, are especially unlikely to move. Third, and relatedly, we expect the largest effects among

people who feel somewhat ambiguous about the parties. (One might think non-leaning independents would be the most ambiguous, but they tend to have relatively few political considerations rather than ambiguous ones (Keith et al. 1986; Klar and Krupnikov 2016).)

Excluding strong partisans also gives us the power to focus on a specific subgroup—"leaners"—and test an additional hypothesis. Klar and Krupnikov (2016) note the rise of "undercover" partisans who claim to be independent but actually lean toward a party. While they show that dislike of political disagreement leads many to go undercover, a lot of the variation remains unexplained. We plan to investigate if they "go undercover" for reasons related to group identity, as much of the partisanship literature would predict.

To maximize power and guarantee equivalence on partisanship across conditions, we plan to block-randomize respondents to the three conditions based on prior partisan self-identification. With 11 "TESS points" of items, we hope to field with $n = 2100$, or roughly 700 respondents per condition. Power calculations are provided in SI 2.

The results from this experiment are liable to shed light on longstanding questions about the role of group identities in partisan politics. In the wake of the 2016 election, answering these questions is more important than ever. An emergent narrative holds that partisan politics has devolved into (or always was) "identity politics."[2] That may be so. But direct evidence for the relationship between people's partisanship and their beliefs about which identities "go with" which parties is liable to put the role of group identity in partisanship on surer footing.

[2] http://www.nytimes.com/2016/11/20/opinion/sunday/the-end-of-identity-liberalism.html

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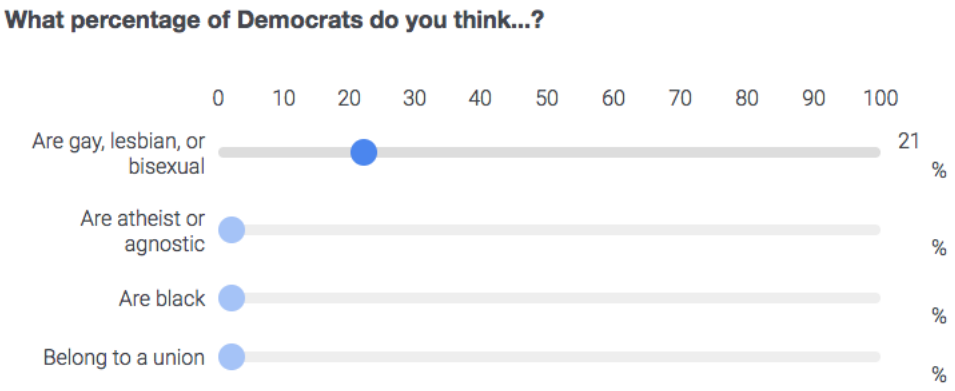
Supporting Information

SI 1 Survey Instrument

Party composition perceptions batteries (from Ahler and Sood (2015))

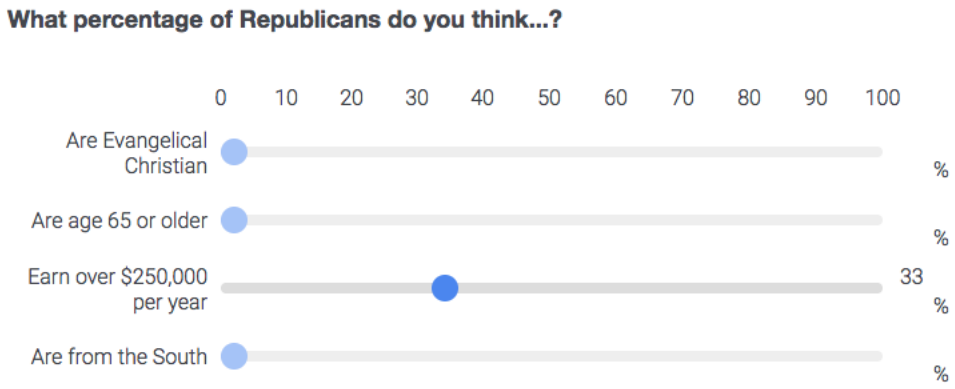
If assigned to the Democratic battery:

Use an instrument similar to this, but replace groups with "Non-white," "Atheist or agnostic," and "Millennials (Age 18-34)"



If assigned to the Republican battery:

Use an instrument similar to this, but replace groups with "Earning $250,000 or more per year," "Evangelical Christian," and "Rural-residing."



Corrections for the "tell" condition

If assigned to the Democratic battery:

The percentage of Democrats who are non-white is [LARGER/SMALLER] than you think. [/ONLY] **43.0%** are not white. (You [UNDER/OVER]estimated by [abs(RESPONSE - 43.0) / .430, 0 decimal places]%.)

The percentage of Democrats who are atheist or agnostic is [LARGER/SMALLER] than you think. [/ONLY] **8.7%** are atheist or agnostic. (You [UNDER/OVER]estimated by [abs(RESPONSE - 8.7) / .087, 0 decimal places]%.)

The percentage of Democrats who are "millennials" is [LARGER/SMALLER] than you think. [/ONLY] **24.7%** are age 18-34. (You [UNDER/OVER]estimated by [abs(RESPONSE - 24.7) / .247, 0 decimal places]%.)

If assigned to the Republican battery:

The percentage of Republicans who are evangelical Christian is [LARGER/SMALLER] than you think. [/ONLY] **34.3%** are evangelical Christian. (You [UNDER/OVER]estimated by [abs(RESPONSE - 34.3) / .343, 0 decimal places]%.)

The percentage of Republicans who are rural-residing is [LARGER/SMALLER] than you think. [/ONLY] **11.3%** live in rural areas. (You [UNDER/OVER]estimated by [abs(RESPONSE - 11.3) / .113, 0 decimal places]%.)

The percentage of Republicans who earn at least $250,000 per year is [LARGER/SMALLER]

than you think. [/ONLY] **2.2%** have an income this large. (You [UNDER/OVER]estimated by [abs(RESPONSE - 2.2) / .022, 0 decimal places]%.)

All respondents assigned to "tell" see and answer this item on the same screen as the corrections. It serves as a manipulation check and an on-screen task to heighten treatment impact:

- Which statement comes closest to your reaction to this information? (The X Party is more like me than I thought, The X Party is less like me than I thought, The X Party is composed about how I thought)

Seven-Point PID Branched Item

- Generally speaking, do you usually think of yourself as a Democrat, a Republican, an independent, or what? (Democrat, Republican, Independent, Other (Please specify below [TEXT BOX]))

If response to Item 1 is "Democrat":

- Would you call yourself a strong Democrat, or a not very strong Democrat? (Strong Democrat, Not very strong Democrat)

If response to Item 1 is "Republican":

- Would you call yourself a strong Republican, or a not very strong Republican? (Strong Republican, Not very strong Republican)

If response to Item 1 is "Independent" or "Other":

- Do you consider yourself closer to the Republican Party or the Democratic Party? (Closer to Republican, Neither, Closer to Democratic)

Expressive partisanship battery (from Huddy, Mason and Aaroe (2015))

Note: For these items, text = "Democrat/Democrats" to all respondents who answer "Democrat" to the first item in the seven-point branched item or who answer "Independent" or "Other" in the first item and then "Closer to Democratic" in the second. Text = "Republican/Republicans" to all respondents who answer "Republican" to the first item in the seven-point branched item or who answer "Independent" or "Other" in the first item and then "Closer to Republican" in the second. Text = "Independent/Independents" to all respondents who answer "Independent" to the first item in the seven-point branched item and then "Neither" in the second. For respondents who answer "Other" in the first item, pipe in [RESPONSE]/[RESPONSE]s if possible.

- How important is being a (Democrat/Republican/Independent) to you? (Extremely important, Very important, Not very important, Not important at all)
- How well does the term (Democrat/ Republican/Independent) describe you? (Extremely well, Very well, Not very well, Not at all)
- When talking about (Democrats/ Republicans/Independents), how often do you use "we" instead of "they"? (All of the time, Most of the time, Some of the time, Rarely, Never)
- To what extent do you think of yourself as being a (Democrat/ Republican/Independent)? (A great deal, Somewhat, Very little, Not at all)

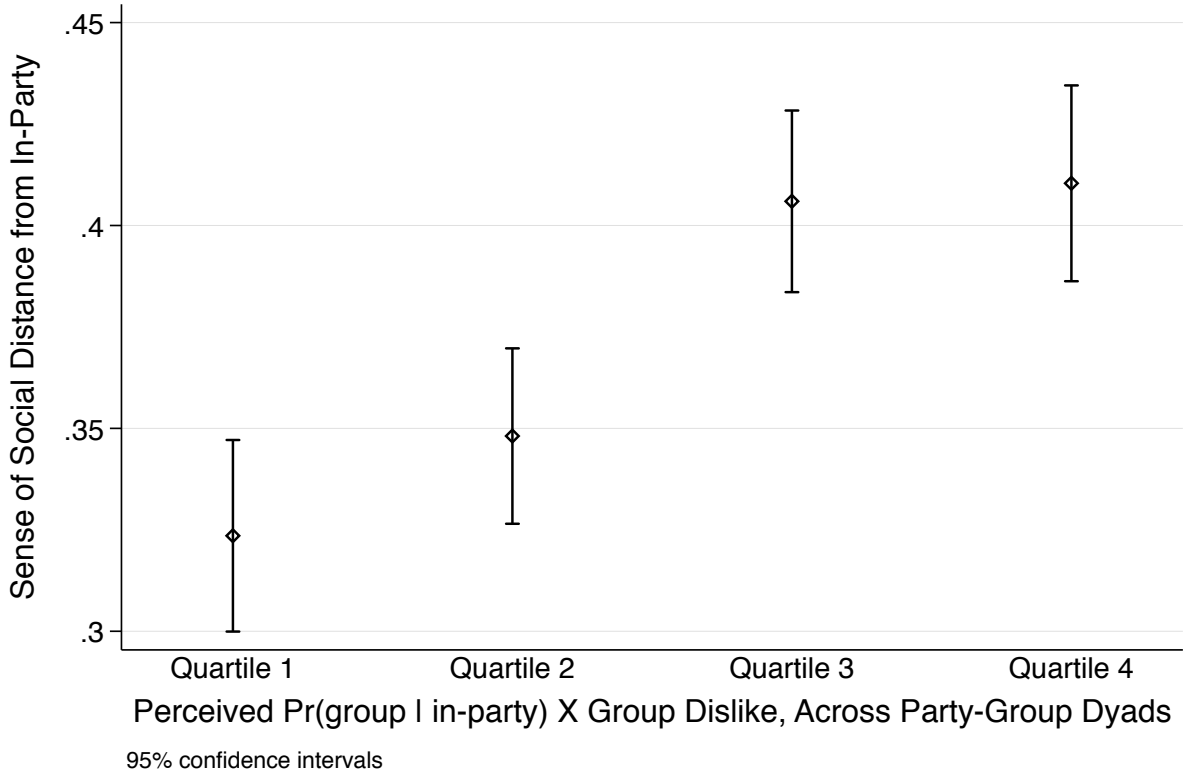
SI 2 Power Analysis for Main Effects

With the sample requested, and conservatively assuming that expressive partisanship is distributed uniformly over the interval $[0, 1]$, with mean 0.5 (as Huddy, Mason and Aaroe 2015 show is roughly the case) and standard deviation 0.29 (from the uniform assumption), the minimum detectable effect between conditions in the full sample is a difference of 0.044. This seems reasonable—Ahler and Sood (2015) find comparable treatment effects on affective expressions of partisanship, using a similar treatment design.

Detecting a treatment effect on the traditional 7-point measure seems harder but not impossible. Assuming that no one in the control group moves (on average), and assuming a standard deviation of 0.35 for a folded partisanship measure (from existing work we have done), 5.2% of respondents in the treatment group would have to become more firm in their partisanship as a response to the treatment to detect an effect. Kuo, Malhotra and Mo (2014) achieve a five-point survey-experimental treatment effect on the 7-point measure measure (among Asian Americans) by priming Asian-American interests and the parties' positions on immigration. Without strong partisans, we expect roughly 40% of the sample to be leaners. Assuming a slightly smaller standard deviation among this group (0.3), we estimate a minimum detectable effect of 7.3% among leaners only. However, this analysis seems particularly well-suited to the calculation of a non-parametric test statistic, which is likely to conserve statistical power (Keele, McConnaughy and White 2012).

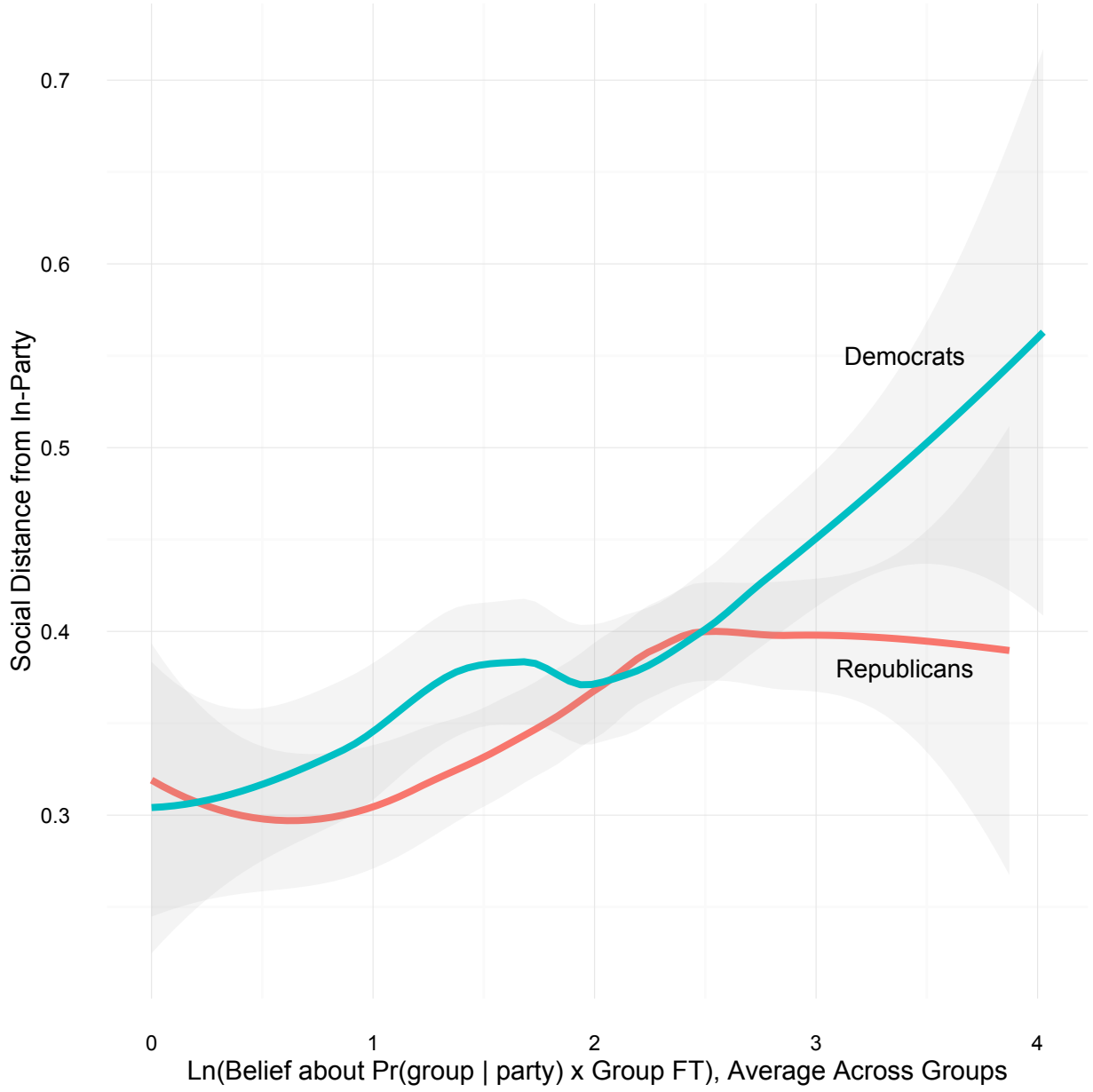
SI 3 Observational Evidence

Figure SI 3.1: Dislike of Party-Stereotypical Groups X Perceived Prevalence of Party Stereotypical Groups (Binned) Predicts Social Distance from In-Party



NOTE: 95% confidence intervals depicted.

Figure SI 3.2: Dislike of Party-Stereotypical Groups X Perceived Prevalence of Party Stereotypical Groups (Logged) Predicts Social Distance from In-Party



NOTE: 95% confidence intervals depicted.